

Scope	Global
Type/Subtype	Governance and Procedure > Guidance
Classification	Main Document
Title	Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents
Document Name	BI-VQD-24416-G
Document Number	BI-VQD-24416
Version	3.0
Previous Document Number	N/A

GENERAL INFORMATION

Applicability Impacted Division(s)	Animal Health, Commercial - R/B-OPU, Development, Global Business Services, Global Facilities & Engineering, Global Quality, Human Pharma, Information Technology, Legal & Compliance, Medicine, Research
Owning/Issuing Division	Global Quality

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

Table of Content

1	PURPOSE	3
2	APPLICABILITY	3
3	DEFINITIONS & ABBREVIATIONS	3
4	IMPLEMENTATION AND/OR PRE-REQUISITES	4
5	ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES	4
6	PRINCIPLES FOR DOCUMENT WRITING	4
6.1	LANGUAGE AND WORDING	5
6.2	ACCESSIBILITY AND UNDERSTANDABILITY OF DOCUMENT	6
6.3	ASSESSING DOCUMENT READABILITY AND LANGUAGE ACCURACY ..	6
6.4	USING ARTIFICIAL INTELIGENCE IN CONTENT CREATION	8
6.5	USE VISUALIZATIONS TO INCREASE TEXT UNDERSTANDING	8
6.5.1	Strategic use of symbols	8
6.5.2	Infographics.....	9
6.5.3	Flow Charts for Process Descriptions	10
7	GUIDANCE FOR SPECIFIC DOCUMENT CHAPTERS.....	11
7.1	ARTICULATE THE PURPOSE.....	11
7.2	DETERMINE THE APPLICABILITY	11
7.3	CLARIFY DEFINITIONS AND ABBREVIATIONS	12
7.4	GUIDELINES FOR IMPLEMENTATION AND PREREQUISITES	12
7.5	IDENTIFY ALL ROLES AND THE RESPECTIVE RESPONSIBILITIES.....	12
8	ASSOCIATED DOCUMENTS.....	14
9	REFERENCES	14
10	DOCUMENT HISTORY	14

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

1 PURPOSE

This Guidance:



Outlines the writing of Boehringer Ingelheim Governance and Procedure Documents (GP Docs) with a focus on human learning principles, readability, and accessibility.



Aims to make GP Docs clearer, leading to a better understanding and practical application.

2 APPLICABILITY

This Guidance is applicable:



To all authors who write GP Docs, except Policies.



All business units/divisions and departments writing GP Docs, except Policies.



World-wide

3 DEFINITIONS & ABBREVIATIONS

Term	Definition / Explanation
Role	See BI-VQD-176246-S: Learning Management.

Abbreviation	Description
AI	Artificial Intelligence (AI) refers to the simulation of human intelligence processes by machines, especially computer systems. These processes include learning (the acquisition of information and rules for using the information), reasoning (using rules to reach approximate or definite conclusions), and self-correction.

Boehringer Ingelheim

Page 4 of 14

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

GP Docs	Governance and Procedure Documents, see BI-VQD-10095-S: Management of Governance and Procedure Documents.
GxP	See BI-VQD-08234-D: Boehringer Ingelheim Quality Manual.

Infographics Description

	Introduction/Executive Summary – short description of what you can expect from the following chapter.
	Explanation – additional information to the topic.
	Attention – notice taken of something interesting or important.
	Key take way - what you should remember after reading.

4 IMPLEMENTATION AND/OR PRE-REQUISITES

Use the principles in this guidance when creating or updating a Directive, SOP, Work Instruction and Guidance.

There is no need to update effective documents due to this Guidance before their periodic review.

5 ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

Role	Responsibility/Accountability	Competence
GP Docs Author	See BI-VQD-10095-S: Management of Governance and Procedure Documents.	Execution

6 PRINCIPLES FOR DOCUMENT WRITING



Enhancing understanding and recall of document subjects is key to practical implementation, ensuring GxP compliance and protecting Boehringer Ingelheim's license to operate. This section outlines key principles for effective document writing to improve reader comprehension:

1. Appropriate Language and Wording
2. Ensuring Accessibility and Readability
3. Utilizing Artificial Intelligence (AI) in writing support
4. Visualization considerations: Symbols, Infographics, Flow Charts

Life forward

Property of Boehringer Ingelheim Group of Companies – Use current version only and according to confidentiality principles

Boehringer Ingelheim

Page 5 of 14

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

Effective communication is crucial for Boehringer Ingelheim's success. Excellence in writing facilitates clear, concise, and engaging communication.



1. Always identify the document's target audience and the target role(s) and their operational needs.
2. Consider splitting complex documents into multiple parts for enhanced readability and clarity, making the information more accessible to the target audience.
3. Have your GP Doc proofread by a diverse group of individuals, e.g., subject matter experts and native speakers (especially if the document is written by a non-native speaker), to verify correctness, understandability, and accessibility.

6.1 LANGUAGE AND WORDING

Principles of Simplified Writing

To make GP Docs more accessible, employ simple language:

1. Active Voice is Key:

Always pair specific role names with active verbs. Use formulations like "GQ authors write new Governance and Procedures Documents" and "The System Owner must perform a system review annually". Avoid passive constructions.

2. Brevity Matters:

Write short, straightforward sentences, ideally not longer than two lines. Avoid superfluous words and repetitions.

3. Global Language:

Avoid idioms or jargon.

4. Stay on Topic:

Keep focused on the central theme.

Effective Word Choice Strategies

- Prefer "confirm" or "verify" over "ensure".
- Do not use "please".
- Use "must" for mandatory processes dictated by regulations or Boehringer's standards.
- Use "should" when the described process is strongly recommended, but variations are possible.
- Use personal pronouns like "I" and "you" where appropriate.

Life forward

Property of Boehringer Ingelheim Group of Companies – Use current version only and according to confidentiality principles

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

- Avoid "may" and "recommend" in process contexts, as well as adjectives, adverbs, and qualifiers like "very" or "carefully."
- Avoid use of conjunctive and phrases like "can be found", "could be found". Use present: "is found".
- Avoid long compound words. If not possible separate them by hyphens or middles (-) to make them easier to understand, e.g.:
Clinicaltrialdatamanagement to Clinical-trial-data-management.

6.2 ACCESSIBILITY AND UNDERSTANDABILITY OF DOCUMENT

Different readers of a document may have different needs regarding understandability and accessibility of the content. When you write a document consider the following aspects to address different needs:

- **Language:** Provide translations as needed, adhere to the BI-VQD-161829-WI: Translation Process. To make your document more readable, refer to chapter [6.3](#).
- **Illustrations and images:** Support your text with visuals and provide descriptions in plain language where necessary, refer to chapter [6.5](#).
- **Use of colour:** Adhere to our corporate colour palette while being mindful of colour vision impairments:
 - **Contrast:** Ensure graphics and coloured text have sufficient contrast. Choose colour combinations with distinct brightness levels to enhance readability, e.g., ensure sufficient contrast ratio between foreground and their background.
 - **Red-green combinations:** Avoid using these, as they are not distinguishable to individuals with red-green colour blindness.
 - **Symbol and colour:** Use symbols consistently and avoid assigning different meanings to the same symbol based on colour alone. When using colours to differentiate or highlight information, always provide an alternative means of identification, such as symbols or patterns.

6.3 ASSESSING DOCUMENT READABILITY AND LANGUAGE ACCURACY

This section offers guidance on using Microsoft Word's built-in tools to improve text readability and check spelling and grammar accuracy. Keep in mind that these tools may not be available for all languages.

Tools Overview

Microsoft Word offers two distinct sets of tools to enhance your document:

Life forward

Property of Boehringer Ingelheim Group of Companies – Use current version only and according to confidentiality principles

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

1. Spelling & Grammar Check:

Run a spell and grammar check with the current language selected. It identifies and corrects spelling mistakes and grammatical errors. This ensures your document is free from common language errors, enhancing its professionalism and readability.

2. Readability Scores:

- Readability scores are metrics to evaluate the ease with which your audience can understand the text. Note that readability scores may not be available for documents in languages other than English.
- Before using this tool, activate the 'Readability Statistics' feature in Microsoft Word by navigating to File > Options > Proofing. In the "When correcting spelling and grammar in Word" section, ensure the box for "Show readability statistics" is checked.
- After running a spelling and grammar check, Word automatically displays readability statistics for documents in English, including:
 - **Flesch Reading Ease:** Scores range from 1 to 100. Higher scores indicate easier readability. Aim for 60 to 70 for general documents. SOPs might tolerate a lower score. A score in the range of 30-50 could still be acceptable, as it indicates the text is likely to be understood by professionals with a good understanding of the topic.
 - **Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level:** Reflects the U.S. school grade level needed for comprehension. General documents should target a grade level of 7 to 8, while specialized documents like SOPs might aim for a grade level of 10 to 12, considering the technical language and the educated audience.
 - **Passive Sentences Readability Index:** In technical writing, some use of passive voice is acceptable, especially when the doer of the action is unknown or irrelevant. A good target might be to have less than 10% of sentences in passive voice to maintain clarity and ease of understanding.

Balancing Technicality and Accessibility

While making the document accessible to a broad range of employees, it is also crucial not to oversimplify technical details that are essential for the correct execution of the procedures. Readability scores are guides, not absolute rules. Always consider your audience's specific needs and adjust your writing accordingly.

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

6.4 USING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN CONTENT CREATION

Artificial Intelligence (AI), including models like ChatGPT, enhances content creation. Benefits include:

- **Efficiency:** AI accelerates content generation, freeing time for refinement.
- **Consistency:** Natural Language Processing (NLP) ensures uniform tone and style.
- **Translation Accuracy:** AI translations are more precise, minimizing miscommunication (refer to BI-VQD-161829-WI: Translation Process).
- **Cost-effectiveness:** Automation lowers content creation and translation costs.

For AI support and examples, visit the EngageAI SharePoint page by entering “EngageAI/” in your browser.

For guidance on AI tools, consult:

- BI-VQD-1157557-G: Guidance for using non-validated AI for activities in GxP environments.
- BI-VQD-188683-G: Artificial Intelligence (AI) for GxP relevant Computerized Systems.



- AI-generated content and translations **always require human review** and editing to ensure content quality.
- Use **only company-approved AI tools**, such as “iQGPT” and “Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat”, to safeguard Boehringer Ingelheim's proprietary knowledge and intellectual property. This ensures compliance with our security and data privacy standards.

6.5 USE VISUALIZATIONS TO INCREASE TEXT UNDERSTANDING

Visual aids (e.g., symbols, Infographics, diagrams, flow charts) play a crucial role in enhancing understanding and engagement.

6.5.1 Strategic use of symbols

Use symbols and signs before colours to define and clarify specific information. The primary characteristic of symbols is their geometric uniqueness. They therefore function independently of the colour scheme if they can be clearly recognized via the brightness contrast.

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

In addition to the symbols used in the infographics (see chapter 6.5.2), six additional green symbols are outlined in chapter 7.1 and 7.2. You may introduce extra symbols if they are defined in the document. Use all symbols consistently throughout the document. Avoid overuse of symbols.

6.5.2 Infographics

Infographics serve as optional educational enhancements, clarifying and emphasizing key points. They should engage the reader with direct calls to action. Ensure clarity in infographics by explaining them in the "Definitions & Abbreviations" chapter.

Use the following four infographics for all GP Docs (global, (cross-) divisional or local).

- Use the "Executive Summary/Introduction" Infographic **at the beginning** of a (longer) **section**. What can the learner expect? Write an educational introduction:



Executive Summary/Introduction (short description of subject). It is provided with Light Blue colour (HEX #D2F2F7).

- Use "Explanation" Infographic in the document **as needed** to accompany more difficult parts of the text:



Explanation section (more detailed information on the subject). It is provided with Accent Green colour (HEX #00E47C).

- Use "Attention" Infographic in the document **as needed** to draw attention to topics to remember or not to mix up:



Attention section (what you should know/not to mix up). It is provided with Light Red colour (HEX #F5CDB9).

- Use the "Key-take-away" Infographic **at the end** of the section. What should the learner remember after reading? Draw attention to the main learning topics to be memorized - with a call to action.



Key-take-away section (what you should remember after reading). It is provided with Light Yellow colour (HEX #FBF9AA).

Do not overload your document with infographics. Consider that colours may draw the attention away from the (non-coloured) main text.

Life forward

Property of Boehringer Ingelheim Group of Companies – Use current version only and according to confidentiality principles

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

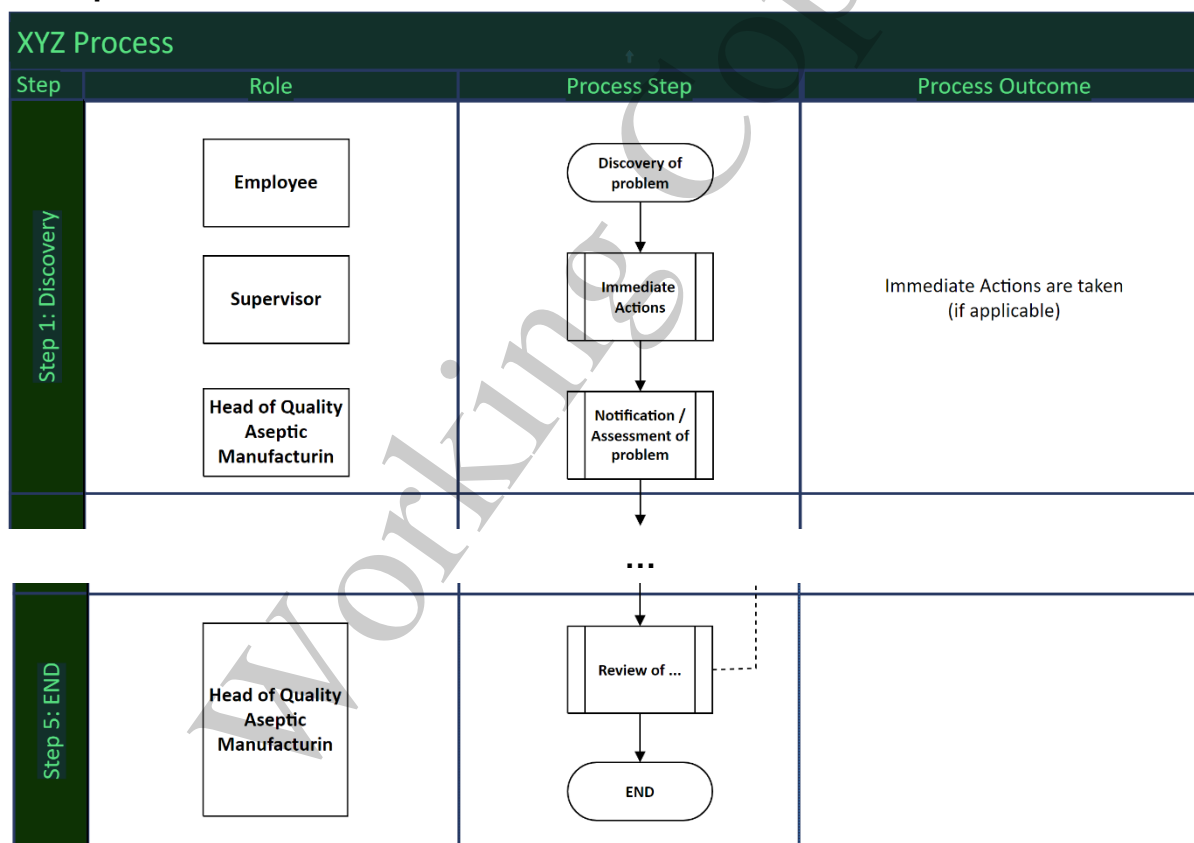
Version: 3.0

6.5.3 Flow Charts for Process Descriptions

Focus on e.g., regulatory-required content in your process descriptions. Use the following four principles for the flow chart, see [Example 1](#) below:

1. Indicate the steps/section.
2. Highlight the involved roles, e.g., via separate boxes.
3. Show the complete process from top to bottom using standardized graphics.
4. Use text to indicate process outcome or remarks.

Example 1: Process visualization.



Embedding of files is not possible in Vault Quality Docs. If you use e.g., Draw.io to create a flow chart, copy a screen shot or copy and paste the chart into your document.

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

7 GUIDANCE FOR SPECIFIC DOCUMENT CHAPTERS

Documents should logically order content/processes, maintaining clarity, consistency, and coherence in symbols, colours, terminology, and writing style.

Break down complex information into smaller segments, using headings and subheadings for organization and navigation.

7.1 ARTICULATE THE PURPOSE

Clarify for the reader the purpose of the document at the beginning. Explain the document subject ("what is described") and the intention ("why you are writing the document"; "what do you want to achieve"). Use the following two green symbols as described:



Brief description of what the document is about? What process is described in the document?



Brief description of the intention. What do you want to achieve?

Do not use these two symbols for other purposes.

7.2 DETERMINE THE APPLICABILITY

Clarify in short sentences for whom this GP Doc is applicable in this section. Use the following four green symbols in your text as described:



Explain which target Roles must follow this document, ensuring accurate training assignment. The more specific you are in describing the Roles where this document is applicable, the better training assignment can be performed.



In which business units, group functions, departments the document applies, according to the applicability defined for impacted divisions and departments in the eDMS.



The applicable geography, e.g., world-wide, R/OPU, country/countries, or site(s).

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0



If applicable, list affected processes/systems and/or materials (if none, delete).

Give additional information below these symbols as appropriate.

Do not use these four green symbols for other purposes.

7.3 CLARIFY DEFINITIONS AND ABBREVIATIONS

It is important for the reader to understand definitions and abbreviations. Define the terms and show the full term for abbreviations as outlined in Chapter 3 “Definitions & Abbreviations” in this Guidance.

Explain the meaning of the Infographics used in your document. If they are not explained in your template/document copy the table in Chapter 3 “Definitions & Abbreviations” of this Guidance into your document. Delete a row/Infographic description in this table if you do not use the respective Infographic in your text.

7.4 GUIDELINES FOR IMPLEMENTATION AND PREREQUISITES

Choose a feasible implementation date or transition period, considering potential conflicts with existing documents, procedures, risk assessments, qualifications, or training, including translations. Updates may necessitate process reengineering or new training initiatives. Allow ample time for these adjustments to avoid non-compliance risks.



For global and (cross-) divisional GP Docs: Not leaving adequate implementation or transition time for adaptations of connected processes or documents may lead to incompliance.

7.5 IDENTIFY ALL ROLES AND THE RESPECTIVE RESPONSIBILITIES

Define all roles within your document in the “Roles & Responsibilities” section, consistently using these role names throughout. Roles outline the responsibility and accountability. If the same role is used in other GP Docs, ensure the role definitions are not contradictory.

List all roles with responsibilities in the process consistently throughout the document. If you do not mention a role in the “Roles & Responsibilities” section, it implies that the

Life forward

Property of Boehringer Ingelheim Group of Companies – Use current version only and according to confidentiality principles

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

role does not have any responsibility in the process. Define for each role the competence level (refer to BI-VQD-176246-S: Learning Management, considering the implementation timeline).

The identified roles will determine the assignment of the document in the Learning Management System (LOS).

Additional information, including a “Role Matrix” for standardized role definitions, is available on the Global Learning Hub (GLH) Intranet page. Type “glh/” into your browser to access this resource.



To ensure effective communication and compliance, it is crucial for you, as an author, to:

1. **Understand Your Audience:** Identify the target audience and their role(s) for each document and their needs. Use writing and design principles that enhance learning.
2. **Clarity and Visuals:** Employ simplified writing techniques to ensure clarity and ease of understanding. Use visuals and colours judiciously to aid comprehension without overwhelming the reader.
3. **Readability and Language Precision:** Assess document readability and ensure language accuracy to maintain high standards of communication.
4. **Leverage AI Tools:** Employ AI tools to streamline content creation and review processes, thereby enhancing efficiency and maintaining high content quality. Ensure adherence to security protocols by using only Boehringer approved AI tools.

Boehringer Ingelheim

Page 14 of 14

Title: Good Writing Practice for Governance and Procedure Documents

Document Name: BI-VQD-24416-G

Version: 3.0

8 ASSOCIATED DOCUMENTS

No.	Name	Title
1	N/A	N/A

9 REFERENCES

No.	Name	Title
1	BI-VQD-08234-D	Boehringer Ingelheim Quality Manual
2	BI-VQD-176246-S	Learning Management
3	BI-VQD-09805-D	Governance and Procedure Documents
4	BI-VQD-1157557-G	Guidance for using non-validated AI for activities in GxP environments
5	BI-VQD-188683-G	Artificial Intelligence (AI) for GxP relevant Computerized Systems
6	BI-VQD-161829-WI	Translation Process
7	BI-VQD-10095-S	Management of Governance and Procedure Documents

10 DOCUMENT HISTORY

Version	Description of Changes	Author
3.0	Revision: The entire document has undergone a comprehensive review. Key updates include the addition of the following new sections: - Accessibility and understandability of document (section 6.2) - Assessing document readability and language accuracy (section 6.3) - Using AI in content creation (section 6.4)	Dr. Marton Klein

Document Approvals
Approved Date: 18 Aug 2025

Author Verdict: Approve	Marton Klein, Dr. (marton.klein@bi-docs.com) Author 02-Jul-2025 14:18:47 GMT+0000
Reviewer Verdict: Approve	André De Freitas Jesus, NULL (andre.de_freitas_jesus@bi-docs.com) Reviewer 02-Jul-2025 14:21:44 GMT+0000
QA and Management Verdict: Approve	Christiane Steur, (christiane.steur@bi-docs.com) QA and Management 03-Jul-2025 06:15:42 GMT+0000